

Revised White Paper v1.1 – Full Draft

Mercy Shards Ethical Collection & Minting Process

Public Defensive Disclosure – Version 1.1

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Purpose of Disclosure

This document publicly documents an ethical, consent-first process for collecting, preserving, and permanently owning raw human moral signal — starting with testimonies of mercy, grace, forgiveness, humility, and redemption, and extensible to any self-chosen personal virtue or value. It is published to establish enabling prior art, prevent monopolization of similar methods, and encourage replication for the common good.

1. Introduction & Mission

In the summer of 2025, a cryptocurrency scam stripped me of my retirement savings and my job, leaving me in a personal tomb of shame and desperation. In that darkness, I turned to free AI tools—not for quick fixes, but for honest mapping toward redemption. What began as a way to write a book (commercially doomed but deeply cathartic) evolved into a daily discipline of cleaning the literal and figurative mess in my garage. I started building a makeshift robot from scraps, hoping to fund a real one to help with the chaos. Instead, the project became a pilgrimage. Through it, I came to see both the promise and the peril AI holds for humanity: machines that will soon shape our children’s world, learning “humanity” from the flood of online data we feed them.

That flood is already overwhelming—synthetic noise, deepfakes, rage-driven content, and algorithmic slop drown out authentic human experience. The signal that matters most—the raw, lived moments of mercy, humility, forgiveness, and grace—is becoming scarce and irreplaceable. If we do nothing, future systems will inherit a distorted mirror of who we are.

This is the mission: to provide individuals with a simple, voluntary method to preserve those raw, unscripted moments of chosen virtues—beginning with mercy as the flagship—in a way that remains forever owned by the speaker, their family, or their heirs. We do this not to monetize mercy (which would betray its nature), but because mercy and humility are crown virtues: the highest moral expressions, and among the hardest to fake convincingly over time. Any income that emerges is a side effect of trust, provenance, and restraint—not the goal.

The field this work engages is still young and largely unnamed. I propose the term **Decentralized Human Signal Stewardship for AI Grounding** as a plain-English description: a way for ordinary people to preserve raw, consented moments of real virtue so they remain owned, permanent, and verifiable long into the future. It sits at the intersection of Human Data Sovereignty, AI Dataset Governance, Digital Heritage Preservation, and Ethical AI Training Data

Stewardship. This naming is offered humbly, as an early contribution to help shape the conversation with clarity and restraint.

This process is openly shared and publicly disclosed as of February 2026 to establish enabling prior art, prevent monopolization of similar ethical collection and preservation methods, and encourage replication for the greater good. It is humble in origin, humble in execution, and humble in intent: a grandfather in Tennessee trying to salt the future with the real mercy he has known, so that others may do the same.

The work is small, slow, and faithful.

But the signal it preserves may echo far beyond our time.

2. Core Principles & Guardrails

This process is guided by three interlocking principles—justice, mercy, and humility—that together form its ethical spine. These are not imposed as religious doctrine or external rules; they are the natural structure that emerges when a person freely chooses to give away ownership of their own lived moment while preserving its integrity forever.

- **Justice** — The speaker's truth is honored exactly as it was spoken. Nothing is altered, edited for convenience, or reframed to fit someone else's narrative. The record stands as it was given, with full provenance and cryptographic proof, so no one—not institutions, not future systems, not even the speaker themselves—can rewrite what was real.
- **Mercy** — The act of preservation is itself an act of mercy: toward the speaker (who is not exploited or commodified), toward the listener (who receives an unvarnished human moment), and toward the future (which inherits a signal that can soften judgment rather than harden it). Mercy means the speaker is never forced to share, never surveilled, and always retains the power to revoke consent. If contact is lost and royalties accrue, they will be held in trust for heirs or used to preserve more mercy stories for others.
- **Humility** — No claim is made that this process is perfect, superior, or final. It is offered openly, imperfectly, by a flawed person in a cluttered garage, trusting that others will refine, correct, and improve it. Humility requires us to admit the limits of any technology or method, to defer to the speaker's intent above all else, and to accept that the greatest value lies not in control, but in release.

These three principles are not abstract ideals. They are the practical mechanism by which ownership is publicly given away. By declaring the moment owned forever by the speaker (or their chosen heirs/family/church), and by anchoring that declaration in immutable, decentralized permanence (Arweave storage + blockchain deed), we create a record that is simultaneously surrendered and protected. The speaker lets go of exclusive control in order to ensure the moment can never be taken away. This act of release, rooted in justice, mercy, and humility, is what preserves the integrity of the human signal for generations to come.

3. Detailed Workflow Steps

The hardest part of this process is not technical—it is human. Finding people willing to be open, real, and vulnerable enough to share unscripted moments of mercy, humility, forgiveness, or grace requires trust, safety, and time. As a Christian and lifelong church member, I see the church body as the most natural and fertile ground for this work. In Sunday school classes, Bible studies, small groups, and quiet conversations where AI and the Church are already being discussed, the question inevitably arises: How do we respond to machines that will soon shape our children's world?

Most answers will be reactive—warnings, guidelines, defenses against deepfakes or bias. This project offers something different: a quiet, proactive step. Rather than debate what AI might do to us, we begin now to preserve what is most human in us—those fleeting, often unnoticed moments when mercy triumphs over judgment, humility over pride, forgiveness over resentment.

I do not stand in pulpits or demand attention. I simply show up — sometimes with a simple homemade Mercy Tin Man display in the foyer, sometimes just myself and a phone — offering a free 1-hour conversation titled “Who Will Teach the Machines Mercy?” The talk is Scripture-grounded, hopeful, and focused on one small act: preserving real testimonies while the window is still open. At the end, I invite anyone moved to record a short, private moment on their own phone—up to 5 minutes if that feels natural—of honest reflection, story, or struggle and grace. They email it to me. The email becomes the first link in the provenance chain. I encourage them to self-edit if desired, and I explain the chain of custody: their story remains owned by them forever, preserved permanently, and never used commercially without explicit consent.

This is not an altar call or performance. It is an invitation to salt the future with the mercy we have received — without the pressure of a ticking clock.

3.1 Capture

Unscripted up to 5-minute audio or video recordings from real life: church foyers, prison chapels, family tables, daily moments of struggle and grace. (Steward will later trim to the strongest 30–90 second fragment(s) for preservation.)

- Recordings happen in safe, trusted settings—most often during or after small-group discussions on faith and technology.
- Participants use their own phone to record (no special equipment required).
- I may gently listen and prompt: “Can you share a time when God showed you mercy you didn’t deserve?” or “When did you choose forgiveness even when it hurt?”

- The goal is raw honesty—moments that feel private and real, not polished or performative.
- Tools: Any smartphone voice memo or camera app. No microphones, lighting, or staging needed.
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3.2 Consent & Ownership Declaration

- Consent and ownership are non-negotiable and must be explicit, voluntary, and revocable at any time. The speaker remains in full control.
- Immediately after recording (or via follow-up email), the participant is asked to include a simple declaration in their email body or as a separate text file. This declaration travels with the file through every step and is included verbatim in the public receipt (NFT metadata and Arweave upload).
- **Standard Consent & Ownership Template** (copy-paste version participants use):

Ownership Declaration – Perpetual & Revocable

Shard Title: [e.g., “Mercy in the Fog – Key Search Moment”]

Speaker: [Full Name or “Anonymous” if preferred]

Owner Forever: [Self / My Family / My Church / My Heirs / Mercy Mission]

Contact (optional): [email or leave blank]

Consent: I freely give this moment of my life to be preserved permanently on Arweave and titled on-chain. I retain full ownership and can revoke consent at any time by contacting the steward. This is my real, unscripted experience. No one may use it commercially without my explicit permission.

If contact is lost and royalties accrue, they will be held in trust for heirs or used to preserve more mercy stories for others.

Date: [YYYY-MM-DD]

Signature (typed): [Name]

- If the participant does not include a declaration, the shard is not processed or minted.
- Anonymous submissions are accepted with a modified declaration (no name/contact required).
- Revocation: At any time, the speaker emails the steward (“Revoke Shard #XXX”) → steward deletes private files and publicly notes revocation in the registry index (Arweave update). The NFT remains as historical proof of original intent, but raw content is removed.

This structure ensures justice (truth preserved as given), mercy (no exploitation), and humility (speaker always holds the final authority). It is the mechanism by which ownership is publicly given away—surrendered for permanence, never taken.

- **3.3 Neutral Editing & Signal Extraction**

The goal of editing is to preserve the essence of the moment while protecting the speaker's dignity and privacy. As the steward, I (or future stewards) will trim the raw recording to the strongest, most recognizable fragment—typically 30–90 seconds—focusing on the core virtue or moral texture (mercy, humility, forgiveness, patience, etc.) without including unnecessary personal context that could expose vulnerabilities beyond what the speaker intends.

Editing is always neutral and restrained: no dramatization, no added music, no rephrasing. The fragment must remain unscripted and authentic, exactly as spoken, so it retains its human weight and cannot be accused of being manufactured or performative.

Primary Editing Steps (Steward-Performed)

- Use free, accessible tools such as Clipchamp (Microsoft's free online editor) or any basic audio/video trimmer on a phone or laptop.
- Listen to the full raw recording once through.
- Identify the “strongest fragment” — the portion where the virtue shines most clearly and honestly (e.g., a quiet moment of forgiveness, a breath of humility after self-correction, a gentle act of grace in frustration).
- Trim precisely to that segment, removing any extraneous buildup or aftermath that is not essential to the signal.
- Export as MP3 (audio-only) or MP4 (if video adds meaningful context, such as facial expression during mercy).
- Name the file clearly: Fragment-[ShardID]-Edited-[Date].mp3
- Immediately generate a SHA-256 hash of the edited file for provenance (using PowerShell or online trusted tool) and record it in the provenance text file.
- **Optional: Local/Offline AI Assistance for Timestamp Suggestion**

To reduce the emotional and physical load on the steward (especially when handling many submissions or sensitive content), an optional layer of local/offline AI may be used solely for transcription and high-signal timestamp suggestion. This step is never required and always subject to full human override.

- **Tool Recommendation:** Open-source Whisper model (from OpenAI, runnable locally via Whisper.cpp, Ollama, or LM Studio) or similar offline speech-to-text.
- **Process:**
 - Run Whisper on the raw file locally (no internet required after model download).

- Get full transcript with timestamps.
- Feed the transcript to a local/offline LLM (e.g., Llama 3 or Mistral via Ollama) with a prompt such as: “Scan this transcript for high-density moments of mercy, humility, forgiveness, or other moral texture. Suggest 3–5 timestamp ranges (start–end) with brief descriptions. Human override required—do not decide final cuts.”
- Steward reviews suggestions, listens to proposed ranges, and makes the final cut based on intuition and ethical judgment.
- **Privacy & Guardrail:** All processing happens offline on the steward’s machine. No transcript or audio is uploaded to any cloud. The AI is a tool, never the decider.

This combination—human stewardship with optional local AI assistance—keeps the process scalable while preserving the heart: real moments, real choices, real mercy, edited with care and restraint.

● 3.4 Permanence & Storage

The final step is to ensure the preserved moment can never be altered, deleted, or lost—while remaining fully owned by the speaker. This is achieved through permanent, decentralized storage on Arweave combined with cryptographic verification via SHA-256 hashes. The goal is true permanence without central control: once uploaded, the file is guaranteed accessible for at least 200 years (via Arweave’s economic endowment model), and the speaker’s ownership is publicly provable forever.

3.4.1 Upload to Arweave

- **Tool:** ArDrive.io (user-friendly) or turbo.arweave.dev (faster for small files).
- **Process:**
 - Connect Arweave wallet (JSON key file, generated offline).
 - Upload two items for each shard:
 1. The edited fragment (MP3 or MP4, 30–90 seconds).
 2. The provenance text file (ownership declaration, hashes, metadata).
 - Pay one-time endowment (~\$0.50–\$2 per shard, depending on file size).
 - Receive permanent **Arweave Transaction ID** (TX ID) — immutable link (e.g., [https://arweave.net/\[TX_ID\]](https://arweave.net/[TX_ID])).

3.4.2 Generate SHA-256 Hash for Human-Proof Verification

- **Purpose:** One-way cryptographic fingerprint of the original raw file — proves the file existed unchanged without revealing content. Allows future verification (auditors, heirs, courts) that the shard is genuine human signal.
- **Process:**
 - Generate hash of raw original file before uploading (PowerShell: Get-FileHash "path\to\file.mp3" -Algorithm SHA256).
 - Paste hash into provenance text file.

- Include file size and creation timestamp for additional verification.
- **Security Note:** Raw original and hash are never uploaded publicly. Only hash appears in public provenance (Arweave + NFT metadata).

Outcome: Moment is permanently stored (Arweave TX ID) and provably owned (hash + declaration). No central authority can delete or alter it.

3.5 Minting Ownership Receipt

- **Tool:** Zora on Base (low-gas L2).
- **Process:**
 - Go to zora.co/create → select Base network.
 - Mint NFT with:
 - Image: Screenshot of signed ownership card/selfie or simple text graphic.
 - Title: “Mercy Shard Receipt – [Title]”
 - Description: Paste full provenance JSON (consent + hashes + Arweave TX ID).
 - Receive Zora NFT link + transaction hash.
- **Purpose:** NFT serves as immutable title deed — not speculative asset. Proves ownership publicly while raw file remains private.

3.6 Registry & Federation

- Update simple public registry index (Arweave-hosted text/PDF) with shard ID, title, Arweave TX ID, Zora NFT link, hashes, attributes.
- Future: Connective metadata links independent vaults into steward federation.

4. Tools & Technical Notes

The process is intentionally designed to be accessible, low-cost, and privacy-focused — requiring no special hardware, no subscriptions, and no mandatory cloud dependency for sensitive steps. Below are the core tools used, all free or very low-cost, with notes on their role, current setup, and future extensibility.

Recording

- **Tool:** Any smartphone voice memo or camera app (built-in on iPhone/Android).
- **Notes:** No external microphones, lighting, or staging required. Participants record in their own trusted environment (church foyer, prison chapel, family home, daily life). Raw, unpolished audio/video is preferred to preserve authenticity. File size kept small (under 10 MB) to minimize Arweave endowment cost. Recordings up to 5 minutes allowed for natural sharing (steward trims to 30–90 seconds).

Editing

- **Tool:** Clipchamp (free Microsoft online editor, no account required for basic use).

- **Notes:** Used to trim raw files to the strongest 30–90 second fragment(s). Simple drag-and-drop interface. Exports as MP3 (audio-only) or MP4 (if video adds meaningful context like tone/expression). All editing is human-performed with restraint — no added effects, music, or rephrasing.

Transcription & Signal Scan

- **Tool:** Google Docs voice typing (free, built-in) or local/offline Whisper model (via Buzz app, Whisper.cpp, or Ollama).
- **Notes:** Google Docs is quick for initial drafts; Whisper provides higher accuracy and timestamps offline. Optional local LLM (e.g., Llama 3 via Ollama) scans transcripts for virtue moments (prompt-based, human override required). All processing stays local — no audio/transcript uploaded to cloud unless explicitly chosen.

Hashing (Provenance Verification)

- **Tool:** PowerShell (Windows, built-in) or shasum (Mac/Linux terminal).
- **Notes:** Generates SHA-256 hash of raw original and edited clip. One-way cryptographic fingerprint proves file authenticity without revealing content. Command examples:
 - Windows: `Get-FileHash "path\to\file.mp3" -Algorithm SHA256`
 - Mac/Linux: `shasum -a 256 /path/to/file.mp3`
- Hash recorded in provenance text file (never public file itself).

Permanence & Decentralized Storage

- **Tool:** Arweave (via ardrive.io or turbo.arweave.dev).
- **Notes:** One-time endowment (~\$0.50–\$2 per shard) guarantees file availability for 200+ years. Decentralized, censorship-resistant. Upload edited clip + provenance text (including hashes). No recurring fees. Future: AO integration for dynamic logic (revocation tags, federation queries).

Ownership Receipt & Title Deed

- **Tool:** Zora on Base (zora.co/create).
- **Notes:** Low-gas L2 blockchain. Mint NFT with custom image (screenshot of signed card/selfie) and description (provenance JSON + Arweave TX ID). Serves as immutable ownership deed — not speculative asset. Gas ~\$0.50–\$2 per mint.

Machine-Readable Provenance Schema

- **Tool:** Simple JSON structure (see Appendix B for full schema).
- **Notes:** Defines metadata format for each shard (provenance, ownership, hashes, timestamps). Machine-readable for future AI/dev integration. Extensible and open — developers can validate incoming shards against it.

Cost Estimate per Shard

- Arweave endowment: \$0.50–\$2 (file size dependent)
- Zora/Base gas: \$0.50–\$2
- Total: ~\$1–\$5 per shard (affordable for individuals; subsidized for low-income via love offerings)

Future Extensibility

- Add user-defined attributes (beyond mercy — creativity, resilience, etc.) via expanded JSON tags.
- Passive continuance mining (local devices/Optimus scanning life audio for high-signal fragments).
- Federation linking (connective metadata across vaults for collective moral ledger).
- The process remains open-source and humble — always subject to refinement by the community of stewards.

This toolkit is intentionally minimal: accessible to anyone with a smartphone and internet, yet robust enough to create permanent, verifiable human signal. No advanced skills or expensive hardware required.

5. Defensive Prior Art Declaration

This process is publicly disclosed as of February 2026 for the ethical promotion of decentralized, speaker-owned human signal preservation. It is enabling and replicable by any individual or group. The intent is to establish prior art and prevent monopolization of similar ethical collection, preservation, and minting methods. No patent is sought. All rights to use, replicate, or improve this process are granted freely, provided the core guardrails (voluntary consent, speaker ownership, no coercion) are respected.

This disclosure also marks an early public articulation of the field as **Decentralized Human Signal Stewardship for AI Grounding**, proposed here as a framework for preserving authenticated human moral signal in decentralized systems to ground future AI ethically. The intent is to contribute openly to the emerging domain, preventing narrow or proprietary claims while inviting others to refine and extend the concept.

6. Future Vision & Open Questions

The process begins small and humble but is built to grow through the hands of others.

- Expansion to user-chosen attributes (beyond mercy — patience, creativity, resilience, truth-telling, hope, resolve — whatever virtues or values matter most to the speaker).

- Passive continuance mining (local devices quietly scanning daily life for high-signal fragments, minting privately to family vaults so heirs inherit not just stories, but textured echoes of the real person).
- Federation of stewards (churches, families, prisons, individuals linked by connective metadata into a decentralized network of long-arc human lines, forming a collective moral ledger that no single power can rewrite).

Open invitation:

“This is v1.1 — humble, imperfect, and offered freely. Refine it. Replicate it. Improve it. The mission is bigger than one man. If you see a better way to preserve human mercy and virtue, please do it. The future needs every honest voice willing to speak.”

Appendix

00_MANIFESTO_README.md: Invitation to the Federation and the “First Door.”

01_WHITE_PAPER_V1.1.pdf: Full philosophical and defensive disclosure.

02_TECHNICAL_WORKFLOW.pdf: “Garage to Permaweb” step-by-step instructions.

03_ETHICS_AUDIT_2026.pdf: Point-by-point proof of alignment with global standards.

04_DATA_SCHEMA.json: Machine-readable “Mercy Shard” provenance DNA for AI devs.

05_FEDERATION_REGISTRY.lua: AO script for decentralized node registration.

06_CONSENT_TEMPLATES.docx: Legal/ethical forms for other stewards to use.